the Afghan and US forces nearly two weeks to jointly recapture Kunduz.[174] Two months later, in December, the Taliban attacked the fortified Kandahar airfield and ended up killing twenty-two Afghan soldiers.[175] Though failing militarily, the Kandahar airfield attack succeeded in splitting the Afghan government. NDS chief Rahmatullah Nabil put in his resignation and openly criticised the government's resistance to dialogue.[176] A Karzai confidante, Nabil's differences with Ghani and Atmar over reconciliation with Pakistan had become irreparable. Further complicating the situation was the rise of a splinter group that pledged support to Daesh/ISIS in Syria and Iraq, but was made of second-rung disgruntled and/or ambitious Taliban commanders.[177] Though concerned about Afghanistan's deteriorating security situation and Ghani's proactive outreach to Islamabad, India warmed up to the new Afghan government as well as the US decision to reverse the withdrawal.

There was a key difference in how India dealt with the NATO drawdown and the Soviet withdrawal. Instead of holding on to Afghan leaders such as Karzai (like it did with Najibullah), India used its increased diplomatic weight to proactively shape the situation in a way that a general post-2001 consensus would be preserved against the Taliban and Pakistan.[178] Adjusting to Russia and Iran's growing convergences with both the Taliban and Pakistan was acceptable in these changing circumstances. But the masterstroke was Menon's decision to involve China and use Beijing's leverage over Islamabad and Rawalpindi to convince or coerce the Taliban to the talking table (Narayanan had little engagement with China on Afghanistan and Pakistan during his tenure as NSA). India's determination was also visible in its support to Karzai at a time when the world was criticising him for heading a corrupt government, taking an unnecessarily hardline against Pakistan, and becoming an obstacle to peace. Knowing well that Kabul was not in a position to set the terms of talks given its capacities limitations relative to Pakistan, New Delhi accepted the challenge to build diplomatic pressures that would push Washington and other international actors to exercise their capacities on the ground in a way that strengthened Kabul's hand at the negotiation table. Combined with a steadily worsening security situation and rise of the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (ISIS), also known as *Wilayat Khorasan*, the idea of reconciliation between Afghanistan and Pakistan as 'equals'